The cabinet, a small body consisting of the prime minister as its head and the cabinet ministers, is the highest decision-making body in the formal sense. However, a still smaller body called the 'Inner Cabinet' or 'Kitchen Cabinet' has become the real centre of power. This informal body consists of the Prime Minister and a few influential colleagues in whom he/she has faith and with whom he/she can discuss every problem. It advises the prime minister on important political and administrative issues and assists him/her in making crucial decisions. It is composed of not only cabinet ministers but also outsiders like friends and family members of the prime minister.

Every prime minister in India has had his/her 'Inner Cabinet'—a circle within a circle. During the era of Indira Gandhi, the 'Inner Cabinet' which came to be called the 'Kitchen Cabinet' was particularly powerful.

The prime ministers have resorted to the device of 'inner cabinet' (extra-constitutional body) due to its merits, namely:

1. It being a small unit, is much more efficient decision-making body than a large cabinet.
2. It can meet more often and deal with business much more expeditiously than the large cabinet.
3. It helps the Prime Minister in maintaining secrecy in making decisions on important political issues.

However, it has many demerits also. Thus,[6]

1. It reduces the authority and status of the cabinet as the highest decision-making body.
2. It circumvents the legal process by allowing outside persons to play an influential role in the government functioning.

The phenomenon of 'kitchen cabinet' (where decisions are cooked and placed before the cabinet for formal approval) is not unique to India. It also exists in USA and Britain and is quite powerful in influencing government decisions there.

Table 21.2 Articles Related to Central Council of Ministers at a Glance

Article No.	Subject Matter
74.	Council of Ministers to aid and advise President
75.	Other provisions as to Ministers
77.	Conduct of business of the Government of India
78.	Duties of Prime Minister as respects the furnishing of information to the President, etc.